



Sharp as she was, nothing escaped her notice. Soon, she figured out what was wrong. That day, I got one of my earliest lessons on the importance of hard work. And a warning, too!" he recollects fondly.

The dreaming of a dream

Being the son of a district superintendent, discipline and good moral values were the cornerstone of Mohan's character formation, but the constant transfers every three years made it difficult for Mohan to stay in touch with his friends. "Every three years it was a new school, new friends, and the old friends were left behind. This lacuna strengthened the bond between my younger sister, Kishori, and I, despite a significant age gap—she's six years younger. Uma is just a year older than me, so we were academic competitors," he recalls.

The dreams of 1960s middle-class Indian parents were aimed at their children becoming doctors or engineers, which were seen as secure jobs. Mohan's mother decided he would become an engineer and his sister a doctor. "I used to joke with my sister, saying if I didn't make it into engineering, I would study medicine—it seemed much easier for those competing in that field," he laughs.

Following his mother's guidance, Mohan strove for perfection, wanting to be the best at everything he did. His teachers recognised his leadership skills, and Mohan earned the title and position of class captain every year. While the accolades and laurels never stopped, for Mohan, something still felt amiss. Pondering over his existence and purpose in life, Mohan felt the need to be different—to make a unique mark and benefit society as a whole. "I did not have the skills to become an artist or a musician. I could have been a scientist. I thought about it a lot



BVR Mohan Reddy receiving Padma Shree Award

and decided to become an entrepreneur—a creator of jobs! That is how I would earn money."

An entrepreneur in the making

The year was 1974. Mohan after graduating in mechanical engineering from the prestigious College of Engineering, Kakinada (Andhra University - Visakhapatnam), went on to pursue M.Tech in Industrial Engineering at the eminent Indian Institute of Technology, Kanpur. He dreamt of becoming a job creator, but the Licence Raj's regulatory challenges and the labyrinthine bureaucracy proposed a ginormous roadblock. The energies of the investors were directed towards winning licences rather than capturing markets or producing superior goods. In such a situation, Mohan did not have the finances or the reach to build a business from scratch. Instead, he focused on enabling himself and continued his education. "The biggest asset that my

parents gave me was my education, and it continues to be my strength, even today. I am always learning. I never stopped," he says.

With just an ambition and the urge to learn, Mohan embarked on gaining experience before putting himself out in the wild. Starting with DCM Group, Mohan, for three years with Shriram Refrigeration, a DCM Group Company, Hyderabad, joining the company as a graduate trainee, Mohan continued working with the company until 1976.

After recalling his first job experience, Mohan says, "I had a mechanical and industrial engineering background, but as a senior management trainee, I had to run a diesel engine assembly shop, managing around 300 workers and getting them to be productive," says Mohan. At 23, even as a trainee, Mohan was priming his brain to develop strategies to streamline the production and shipping of 450 diesel engines throughout a six-day working week.